

Style II: Minimalism, Structure

The Fundamentals of Tech Writing | BUT 2026

The Red Hat Customer Content Services team

Style I

- What is style?
- Goals of tech writing
 - Accessibility
 - Readability
 - Findability
- User focus

→ Style II ←

- Minimalism
- Topic-based authoring
- Style guides



What do we know about the tech writing style so far?





Minimalism

"I didn't have time to write you a short letter, so I wrote you a long one." - Blaise Pascal

Fewest **necessary** words/elements to convey info.

- User focus: action orientation
- No fluff
- Findability
- Titles, headings
- Error recovery, verification, troubleshooting

Minimalism in practice: examples

- Upon completion of the first step, proceed with completely removing the ***cruft*** file, which at this point is redundant.



2. Delete the ***cruft*** file.

- In order to load a snapshot that you or somebody else have previously created, there is the eminently useful ***virsh snapshot-revert*** command, which you can use in the CLI.



To load a snapshot, use the ***virsh snapshot-revert*** CLI command.

Minimalism in practice: homework examples

- Before using virt-sysprep, make sure it's actually installed on your machine.



Prerequisites:

- *Virt-sysprep* is installed on your system.

- When it comes to the templating itself, first off, if you'd like, you can make a copy of the VM's disk image, so you can later check that the sysprep went through hiccup-freely.



Procedure:

1. Optional: Copy the VM's disk image

You can later use this image to verify that the procedure succeeded.

Sample homework solution

11.2.1. Creating a virtual machine template by using virt-sysprep

To create a cloning template from an existing virtual machine (VM), you can use the `virt-sysprep` utility. This removes certain configurations that might cause the clone to work incorrectly, such as specific network settings or system registration metadata. As a result, `virt-sysprep` makes creating clones of the VM more efficient, and ensures that the clones work more reliably.

Prerequisites

- The `guestfs-tools` package, which contains the `virt-sysprep` utility, is installed on your host:

```
# dnf install guestfs-tools
```



- The source VM intended as a template is shut down.

Procedure

1. Ensure you are logged in as the owner of the VM's disk image:

```
# whoami  
root
```



2. Optional: Copy the disk image of the VM.

```
# cp /var/lib/libvirt/images/a-really-important-vm.qcow2 /var/lib/libvir
```



This is used later to verify that the VM was successfully turned into a template.

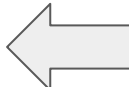
3. Use the following command, and replace `/var/lib/libvirt/images/a-really-important-vm.qcow2` with the path to the disk image of the source VM.

[Full document here](#)

Minimalism ≠ low charcount

*“The objective of golf is to play
as little golf as possible.”*



BAD	BETTER	GOOD	NO WAIT GO BACK!
Below, there is a table that contains a list of cats...	The following table lists cats...	<i>Table 1: Cats</i>	Cats  Lacks context
In order to become a better technical writer, you should adhere to the following five simple rules and principles:	To become a better technical writer, adhere to the following five rules:	To become a better technical writer, follow these rules:	Become a better TW by:  Hard to localize
1. Enter the <code>useradd</code> command on the command line in order to create a new user, like so: <code># plusr</code>	1. To create a new user, enter the following command: <code># plusr</code>	1. Create a new user: <code># plusr</code>	1. Enter: <code># plusr</code>  Unclear
The <code>audit</code> daemon was internally restructured and thereby received a new technique called <code>incremental_async</code> .	The <code>audit</code> daemon now includes a new technique called <code>incremental_async</code> .	The <code>audit</code> daemon includes a new <code>incremental_async</code> technique.	<code>incremental_async</code> added to <code>audit</code>  Ambiguous

Simple language

- ▶ Restricted vocabulary
- ▶ Restricted grammar
- ▶ 3 Cs: clear, concise, consistent language
- ▶ Remove text with low informational value, but:
 - Use full sentences.
 - Provide necessary context.

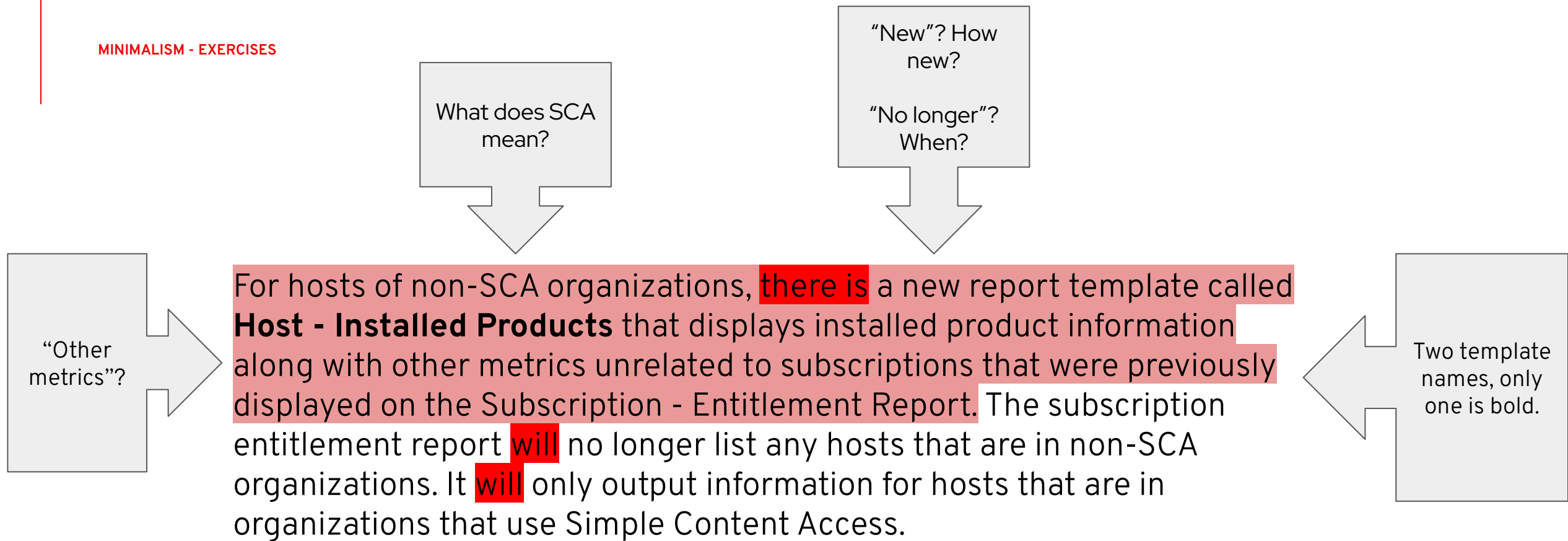
Think about Adam!



Tenses

- ▶ Simple present (SVO)
 - Cockpit loads a certificate. ~~The certificate will be loaded by Cockpit.~~
- ▶ Imperative
 - Open the web interface.
 - Click **System**.
 - Select **Restart**.
- ▶ Infinitive
 - To verify the previous configuration, open the web interface.
- ▶ Active voice vs. passive voice
 - Install the *schmackage* package. vs. The *schmackage* package is installed.
 - ~~The path of the rule is fixed.~~ vs. Bash remediation fixes the path of the rule.

For hosts of non-SCA organizations, there is a new report template called **Host - Installed Products** that displays installed product information along with other metrics unrelated to subscriptions that were previously displayed on the Subscription - Entitlement Report. The subscription entitlement report will no longer list any hosts that are in non-SCA organizations. It will only output information for hosts that are in organizations that use Simple Content Access.



The following templates are available:

Host - Installed Products

Use this report template for hosts that are not part of a Simple Content Access (SCA) organization.

This report displays installed product information and [other metrics unrelated to subscriptions].

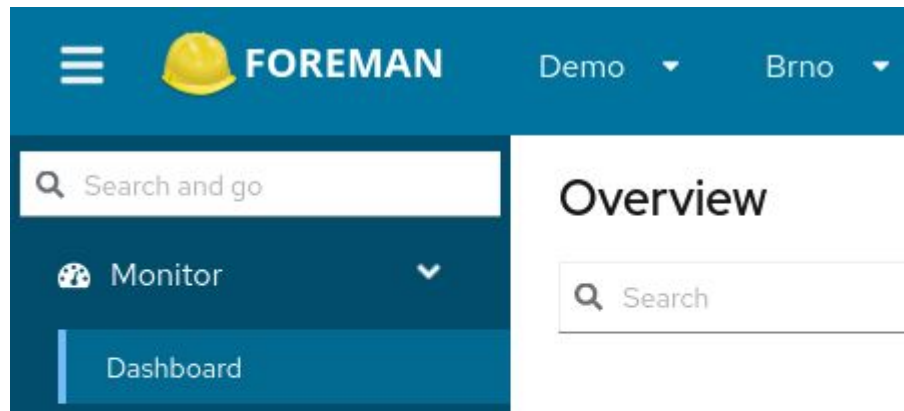
Subscription - Entitlement Report

Use this report template for hosts that are part of an SCA organization.

This report displays [other metrics unrelated to subscriptions].

The Satellite web UI features powerful search functionality which is available on most pages of the web UI. It enables you to search all kinds of resources that Satellite Server manages. Searches accept both free text and syntax-based queries, which can be built using extensive input prediction. Search queries can be saved as bookmarks for future reuse.

As you start typing a search query, a list of valid options to complete the current part of the query appears. You can either select an option from the list and keep building the query using the prediction, or continue typing.

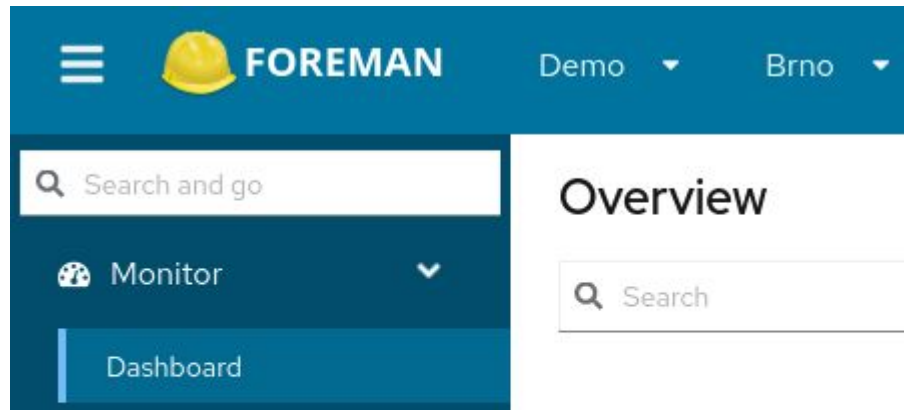


If it's
available, I'll
see it with
my own
eyes!

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Yep, that's
how search
bars work.
I know.

As you start typing a search query, a list of valid options to complete the current part of the query appears. You can either select an option from the list and keep building the query using the prediction, or continue typing.



Restoring from backup

1. Copy the backup data to Satellite Server's local file system. Use `/var/` or `/var/tmp/`.
2. Run the restoration script.
`# satellite-maintain restore /var/backup_directory`
Where `backup_directory` is the time-stamped directory or subdirectory containing the backed-up data.
The restore process can take a long time to complete, because of the amount of data to copy.

For troubleshooting, you can check `/var/log/foreman/production.log` and `/var/log/messages`.

Restoring from backup

1. Copy the backup data to **Satellite Server's** local file system. Use `/var/` or `/var/tmp/`.
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```
# satellite-maintain restore /var/backup_directory
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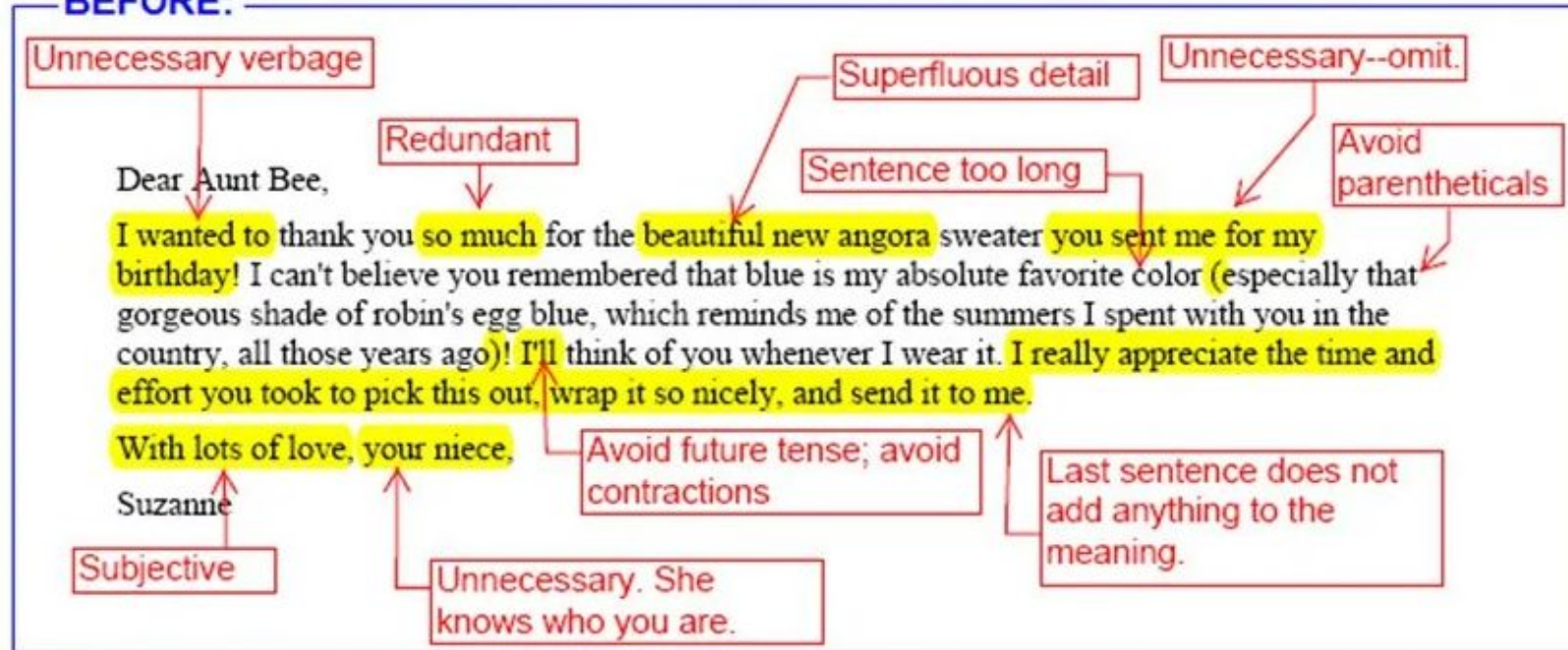
Do we need details about when to choose which to help users decide?

Useful information. Where would be the best place for it?

Do we need details about how to interpret the logs?

How a career in technical communication ruined me as a letter writer

BEFORE:



AFTER:

Dear Aunt Bee,

Thank you for the sweater. It is:

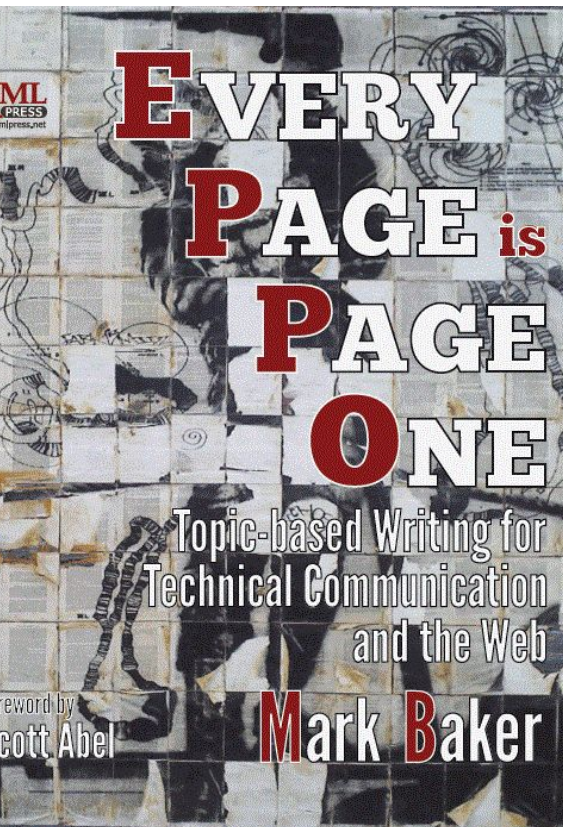
- Warm
- Soft
- Blue

I think of you when I wear the sweater. I appreciate your kindness.

Sincerely,

Suzanne

Thank you for the sweater.



Topic-based authoring

- Readers always online
- All content accessed through the Web
- Books are hierarchical
- Web-like content is anti-hierarchical
- Each topic must stand on its own

“Even when content is not on line, the reader is. We don’t go online anymore, we are online all the time. All content is consumed in the context of the Web where Every Page is Page One.”

- Mark Baker

I. Preparing for your Red Hat Enterprise Linux installation

1. Supported RHEL architectures and system requirements
2. RHEL installation methods
3. Downloading a RHEL installation ISO image
4. Creating a bootable installation medium for RHEL
5. Preparing an installation source

II. Installing Red Hat Enterprise Linux on AMD64, Intel 64, and 64-bit ARM

6. Recommended steps
7. Booting the installation
8. Installing RHEL using an ISO image from the Customer Portal

Chapter 6. Recommended steps

Preparing for your RHEL installation consists of the following steps:

Steps

1. Review and determine the installation method.
2. Check [system requirements](#).
3. Review the installation boot media options.
4. Download the required installation ISO image.
5. Create a bootable installation medium.
6. Prepare the installation source.

This is only required for the Boot ISO (minimal install) image if you are not using the Content Delivery Network (CDN) to download the required software packages.

Shouldn't it be here?

Self-ref, low-info

How?

Where?

What's "this"?

What's the point?

Wonky TOC

Procedure (task, how-to)



- ▶ Title
- ▶ Abstract / Short intro
- ▶ Prerequisites
- ▶ Numbered steps
- ▶ Verification

Poorly structured procedure

Poorly readable heading

What is a template Capsule?

When am I supposed to do this?
Why?
How?

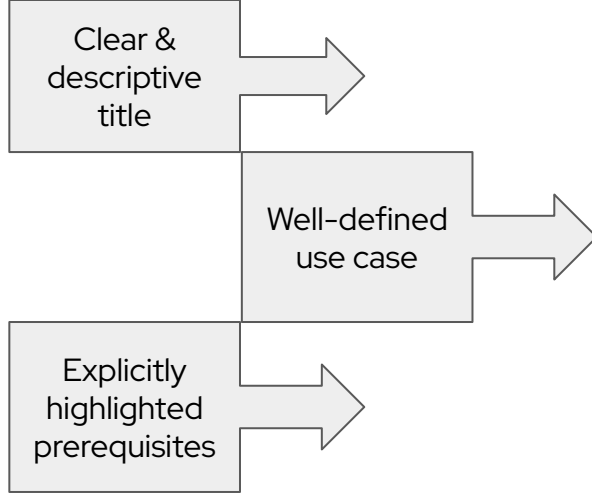
Verifying Subnets have a Template Capsule

Ensure all subnets with discovered hosts have a template Capsule:

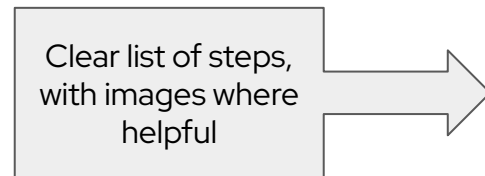
1. In the Satellite web UI, navigate to Infrastructure > Subnets.
2. Select the subnet you want to check.
3. On the Capsules tab, ensure a Template Capsule has been set for this subnet.

Nothing on template Capsules under this link.

For more information about configuring subnets with template Capsules, see [Configuring the Discovery Service](#) in the Provisioning guide.



A well-structured procedure



8.3. Renaming virtual machines by using the web console

You might require renaming an existing virtual machine (VM) to avoid naming conflicts or assign a new unique name based on your use case. To rename the VM, you can use the RHEL web console.

Prerequisites

- The web console VM plug-in [is installed on your system](#).
- The VM is shut down.

Procedure

1. In the **Virtual Machines** interface, click the Menu button [:] of the VM that you want to rename.

A drop-down menu appears with controls for various VM operations.

2. Click **[Rename]**.

The **Rename a VM** dialog appears.

Rename VM Grid_v2

New name: Grid_v2

Rename Cancel

3. In the **New name** field, enter a name for the VM.
4. Click **[Rename]**.

Verification

- Check that the new VM name has appeared in the **Virtual Machines** interface.

GROUP EXERCISE

- ▶ Rewrite in a style more appropriate for documentation. Don't just rewriting the sentences, try to also think about the aim of the text.

The allowerasing flag

The allowerasing flag allows one to erase installed packages to resolve dependencies, hence it remediates dnf commands in situations where dnf'ing would not have been otherwise possible.

Use the respective dnf command including the flag if experiencing difficulties with dependencies. This makes dnf understand it can axe dependencies that get in the way. E.g. please use ***dnf upgrade --allowerasing*** to upgrade your rpms in spite of dependency errors.

This flag could be used as an alternative to the yum swap command where packages to remove are not explicitly defined.

GROUP EXERCISE - possible solution

- ▶ Focus on the feature -> Focus on the aim of the reader

Troubleshooting DNF commands

- If a DNF command fails with a "*Broken dependencies*" error, use the "*--allowerase*" option. This makes it possible for the command to remove installed packages, which in some cases fixes the problem.

For example, to upgrade your system packages:

```
# dnf upgrade --allowerase
```

- *[...more troubleshooting tips...]*

Style guides



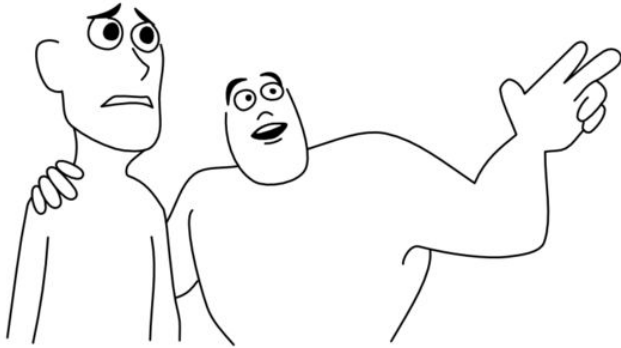
*"Follow a style guide,
you must."
- Master Yoda, never*

*"Y u gib me a
guiding? Am style."
- all shibas, always*



Rewrite the following sentences as memes

Use <https://knowyourmeme.com/> as your style guide.



- Press CTRL+ALT+DEL to open the task manager. (Yoda speak)
- There are bugs occurring. (X, X everywhere)
- It works now. (Doge speak)
- You must be the administrator to do this. (Joseph Ducreux)
- I'm sure I typed the password correctly. (Y U NO)
- Update the system to receive security patches. (1337 sp34k)

-> Feel free to post the results of your work on Discord! :-)

Does this seem familiar?

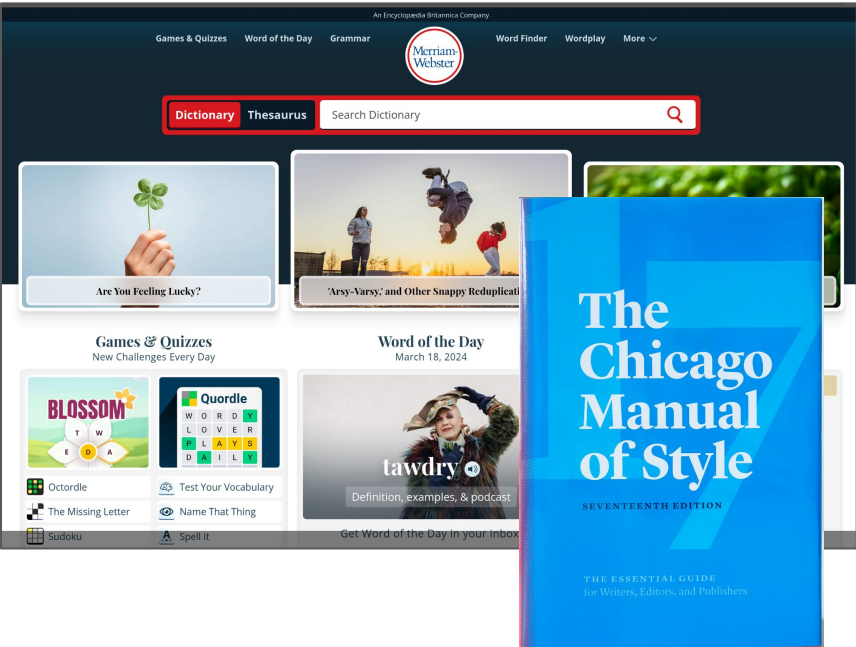
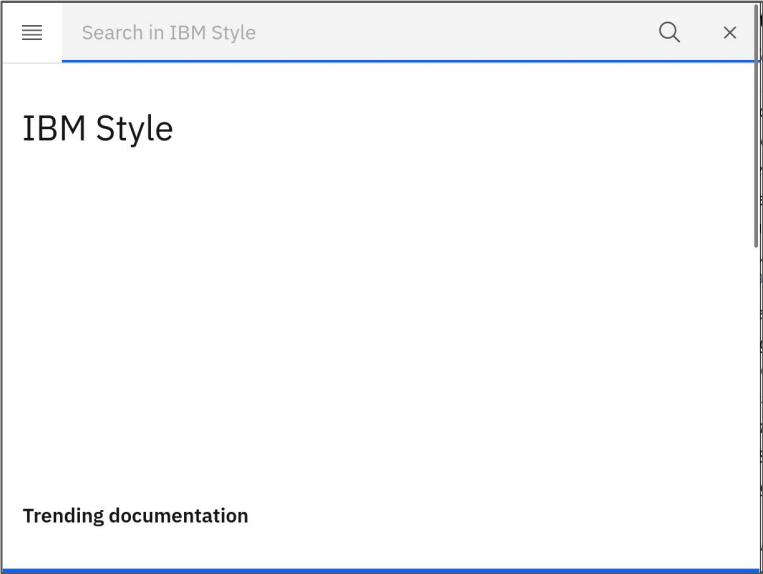
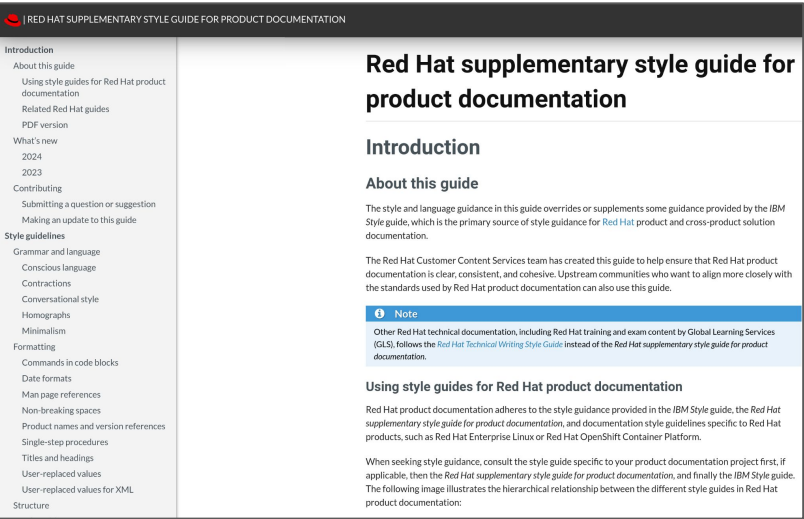
Follow these style rules when doing the assignment:

- *Use simple language.*
- *Avoid anthropomorphisms.*
- *Avoid the passive voice.*
- *Avoid using 'will'.*
- *Avoid phrasal verbs.*
- *Avoid long sentences.*
- *Avoid using words that are unclear and ambiguous.*
- *Make the names of specific commands, utilities, pathways, and filenames visually distinct by using monospaced font.*

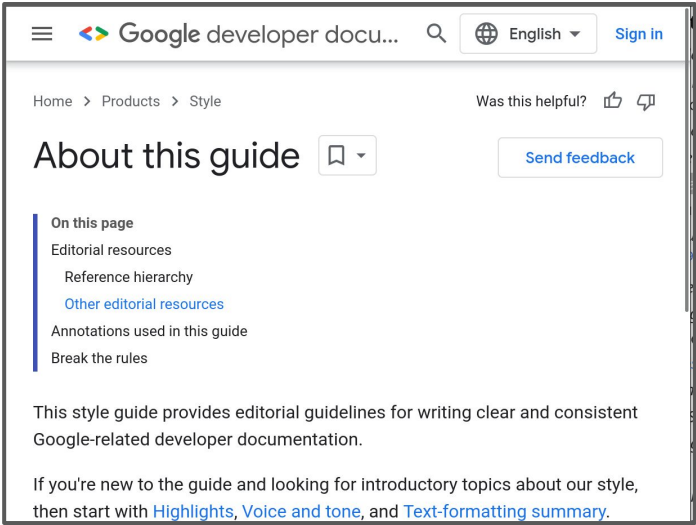
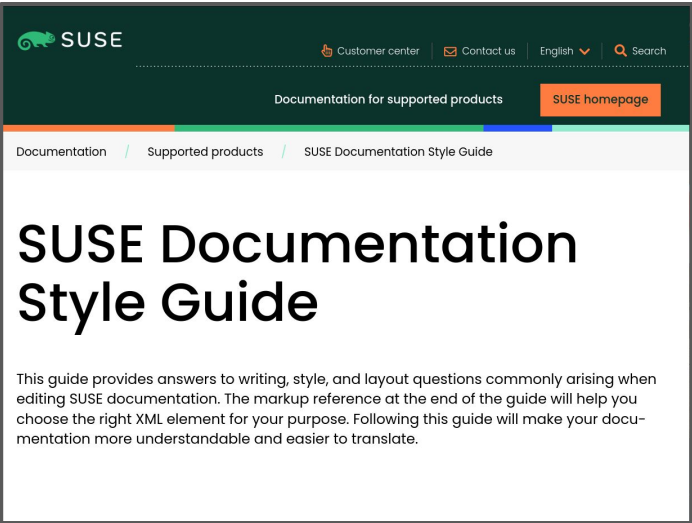
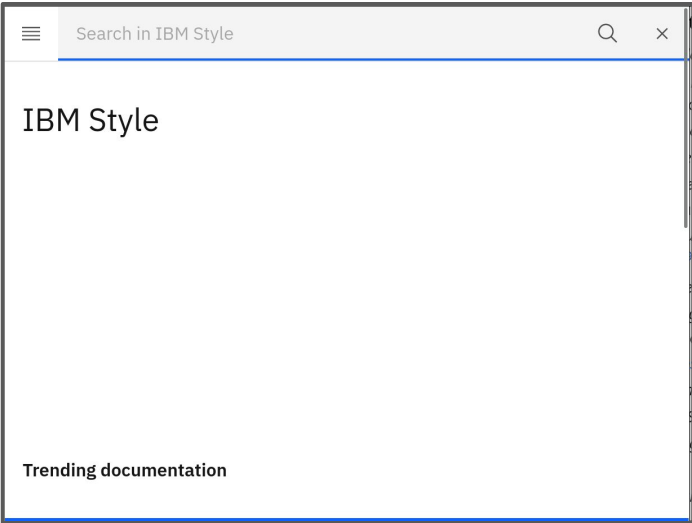
Most specific

Specific

Most general



Major Style Guides



What do style guides govern?

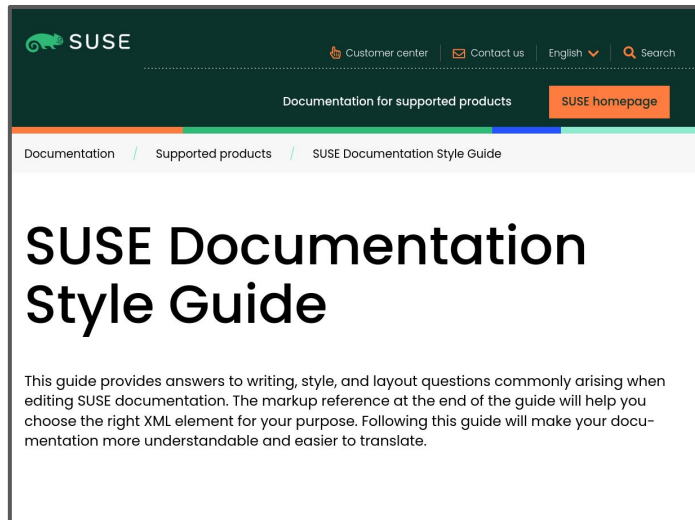
- ▶ **Tone**
 - level of formality in various contexts
- ▶ **Minimalism**
 - specifics of what is and isn't fluff
- ▶ **Numbers**
 - what to write in words, how to write ordinal numbers, etc.
- ▶ **Capitalization**
 - when to use uppercase and lowercase
- ▶ **Abbreviations**
 - expanding acronyms, using latin abbreviations, etc.
- ▶ **Punctuation**
 - using periods in lists, using Oxford comma, etc.
- ▶ **Highlighting**
 - what sort of highlighting to use for what elements
- ▶ ...and more

EXERCISE 1

Find the guidance for the following features in various style guides:

1. "plug-in" / "plugin" / "plug in"
2. Non-exhaustive lists ("like", "such as", "etc.")
3. Contractions ("don't", "isn't") and possessives ("user's")
4. "above", "below", "upper left"
5. Moving through content on a touchscreen

<https://documentation.suse.com/style/current/html/style-guide-adoc/index.html>



<https://support.apple.com/guide/applestyleguide/>



<https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/style-guide/>



What style guides are for

- Unify tone of voice from many writers
 - Different organizations want to convey different tones in their documentation.
 - Formal vs. informal vs. casual
 - Different audiences might be addressed in different tones or terms
 - API documentation vs. an installation guide
- Help resolve difficult questions (such as excessive minimalism over ally or UX)
- Provide rules and training materials for TWs

What style guides are NOT

- Grammar books or vocabularies
- Markup guides
- Replacements for making stylistic choices
- Docs type templates
- Eternal, immovable entities



Summary

- Best practices for style in tech writing:
 - Use simple, direct, translation-friendly language.
 - Use visual structure and formatting to make the text easy to read.
(Topic-based authoring helps)
 - Focus on helping the reader accomplish a specific goal.
 - Say as much as possible in as few words possible (~minimalism).
 - Stick to a single style (guide)

In-class assignment

Team-based workshop on style guides

[Document to copy](#)

Homework!

How to edit other people's content without pissing them off

[Video to watch](#)

Thank you